

DTF Cheat Sheet: Household Iron

● SUB CAMP 2026 · NINJA TRANSFERS

No heat press? No problem. The iron in your laundry room can do this.

Iron settings by fabric

No steam, ever. Use a hard, flat surface (not an ironing board cushion). Parchment paper between iron and transfer always.

FABRIC	IRON DIAL	TIME PER SECTION · PRESSURE
Cotton (light or dark)	Cotton / Linen (highest)	20s · firm
50/50 blends, triblends	Wool / Synthetic-High	20s · firm
Polyester, jerseys, mesh	Synthetic (medium)	20s · firm + pillow
Denim, canvas, heavy	Cotton / Linen (highest)	25s · extra firm
Hoodies (multi-layer)	Cotton / Linen (highest)	25s · firm + pillow under seams
Hats / structured goods	Not recommended with an iron — use a heat press or EasyPress Mini.	

Steps

1. Tape the transfer down with thermal heat tape so it can't shift.
2. Set the iron to the highest setting your fabric will tolerate.
Steam off.
3. Cover the transfer with parchment paper.
4. Press firmly for 20 seconds, then move to the next overlapping section. Every spot gets the full time.
5. Lift only when the whole design has been covered evenly.

The Peel

Wait at least 5 seconds after lifting the iron, then peel the film in one smooth motion. Hot peel is fine — the transfer just needs to still be warm.

If any part of the design lifts, lay it back down, press that spot another 10 to 15 seconds firmly, then re-peel.

NO STEAM — EVER

Steam under a DTF transfer ruins the adhesive bond. Empty the iron's water tank before you start.

The Second Press

DON'T SKIP THIS

The step most crafters skip is the one that matters most for wash durability.

After peeling, cover the design with fresh parchment (or a single layer of T-shirt material) and press again at the **same setting for 15 seconds**. Improves hand feel, reduces shine, locks in long-term wash performance. Wait 24 hours before the first wash.

When Something Goes Wrong

ISSUE	FIX (NINJA TRANSFERS)
Adhesion appears incomplete	Reposition and press again with additional pressure and time.
Portions lift during peeling	Lay the transfer back down and press with firm pressure for 10 to 15 additional seconds.
Wrong temperature for fabric	Check your garment's care label and adjust your settings accordingly. For sensitive synthetics, start 20 to 30 degrees cooler than standard cotton settings.
Forgetting protective cover sheets	Always use a protective guard sheet or parchment paper over your garments.
Skipping the second press	Cover your exposed design with a protective guard sheet and press for about 10 to 15 seconds using the same temperature and pressure settings.

What You Can Press Next

Same iron, different transfer. Once you nail cotton, none of these are scary.

Hoodies

Fleece

Denim

Tote bags

Dark cotton

Heavy cotton

Glow

Foil

Glitter

Spangle